HackForge 2026 — Official Hackathon Guidelines

Build What Matters

Dates: 17–19 April 2026
Mode: Hybrid (Online + Grand Finale Onsite)
Primary Communication Platform: Discord
Duration: 48 Hours
Theme: *AI for Real-World Impact*
Organized by: HackForge Community + Innovation Labs Network
Expected Participation: 2,500+ students, developers, designers, researchers, founders, and builders

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1. Introduction

Welcome to **HackForge 2026**, a 48-hour innovation sprint designed to bring together builders, dreamers, coders, designers, storytellers, researchers, and product thinkers to solve real-world problems using technology.

HackForge 2026 is not just a coding competition. It is a **problem-solving ecosystem** where teams identify pressing issues, design practical solutions, and turn ideas into working prototypes within a constrained time frame. Participants will receive access to mentors, curated datasets, APIs, workshops, networking sessions, sponsor challenges, and an active Discord support community.

This document serves as the **official rulebook and participant guide** for the event. All registered participants are expected to read and comply with the contents of this handbook. In case of conflict between verbal announcements and this written document, **official updates posted in the announcements channel and event website shall prevail**.

By participating in HackForge 2026, you agree to abide by all rules, timelines, and policies mentioned herein.

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2. About HackForge 2026

HackForge 2026 is a flagship interdisciplinary hackathon focused on **AI, software, data, climate, accessibility, fintech, healthcare, productivity, and developer tools**.

The event is designed to:

- encourage practical innovation,
- enable collaboration across domains,
- provide hands-on mentorship,
- create startup-worthy and portfolio-worthy projects,
- help participants learn by building.

This year's edition emphasizes **responsible, useful, and deployable technology** rather than only flashy demos. Teams are encouraged to build products that solve real problems for real users.

Participants may build:

- web applications,
- mobile apps,
- AI agents,
- chatbots,
- browser extensions,
- automation tools,
- dashboards,
- APIs,
- ML systems,
- assistive tools,
- community platforms,
- open-source developer tools,
- data-driven decision systems,
- or hardware-integrated software prototypes (where feasible).

3. Vision & Purpose

The core vision of HackForge 2026 is simple:

> **“Build technology that is useful, inclusive, and scalable.”**

We believe hackathons should reward more than speed. Great products emerge when teams combine:

- user empathy,
- technical execution,
- clarity of purpose,
- design thinking,
- and iterative problem solving.

We are especially interested in solutions that address:

- accessibility barriers,
- education inequity,
- healthcare friction,
- environmental sustainability,
- productivity bottlenecks,
- financial inclusion,
- misinformation,
- small business enablement,
- mental well-being,
- and developer efficiency.

HackForge 2026 aims to be beginner-friendly while still providing enough challenge and technical depth for advanced teams.

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4. Important Dates

Registration Opens

1 March 2026 — 10:00 AM IST

Registration Closes

12 April 2026 — 11:59 PM IST

Team Editing Deadline

14 April 2026 — 11:59 PM IST

Discord Onboarding + Orientation

15 April 2026 — 6:00 PM IST

Workshop Day

16 April 2026 — 4:00 PM to 9:00 PM IST

Hackathon Kickoff

17 April 2026 — 6:00 PM IST

Mentorship Windows

18 April 2026 — All Day
19 April 2026 — Morning

Submission Deadline

19 April 2026 — 6:00 PM IST

Top 25 Announcement

22 April 2026

Final Demo Day

26 April 2026

Winners Announcement

26 April 2026 — Closing Ceremony

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5. Eligibility Criteria

HackForge 2026 is open to participants from a wide range of backgrounds.

Who Can Participate

Participants must fall into at least one of the following categories:

- Undergraduate students
- Postgraduate students
- PhD scholars
- Recent graduates (graduated within last 2 years)
- Early-stage developers and independent builders
- Designers, product thinkers, and researchers
- Open-source contributors
- Startup enthusiasts

Age Requirement

Participants should generally be **16 years or older**. Participants under 18 may be required to provide guardian consent depending on local regulations and finalist travel requirements.

Geographic Eligibility

The hackathon is open to participants globally unless restricted by local laws. Finalists shortlisted for the onsite showcase may need valid travel documents.

Skill Requirement

There is **no minimum skill requirement**. Beginners are welcome. Teams are encouraged to include diverse roles such as:

- frontend developers
- backend developers
- ML engineers
- UI/UX designers
- data analysts
- domain experts
- product managers

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6. Registration Process

All participants must register through the official HackForge 2026 registration form or platform.

Registration Steps

1. Fill out the participant registration form.
2. Verify your email address.
3. Join the official Discord server.
4. Complete your participant profile.
5. Create or join a team before the team formation deadline.
6. Accept the code of conduct and participation policy.

Registration Information Required

Participants may be asked to provide:

- full name
- email address
- institution / organization
- year of study / role
- GitHub / LinkedIn / portfolio (optional but recommended)
- area of interest
- skills
- T-shirt size (if applicable)
- city / country
- dietary or accessibility requirements (for onsite finalists)

Important Note

Registration is **not considered complete** unless the participant has joined the official Discord and verified their account.

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7. Team Formation Rules

HackForge 2026 is a **team-based hackathon**, but solo participation is also permitted.

Team Size

- Minimum team size: **1**
- Maximum team size: **4**

Allowed Team Structures

Examples of valid team structures:

- 1 developer
- 2 developers + 1 designer
- 2 developers + 1 ML engineer + 1 product person
- 3 developers + 1 domain expert

Team Changes

Teams may edit their composition until the **Team Editing Deadline**. After that, no changes will be permitted except under exceptional circumstances approved by organizers.

Cross-College / Cross-Country Teams

Yes, teams can be formed across institutions and geographies.

Disqualification Risks

Teams may be disqualified if they:

- exceed team size limits,
- submit under multiple team names,
- plagiarize another team's work,
- include fake members,
- misrepresent team contributions.

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8. Participation Categories

Participants may identify under one or more categories to help with networking, matchmaking, and mentorship.

Suggested Categories

- AI / ML
- Full Stack Development
- Data Science
- Design / UX
- Product / Strategy
- Blockchain / Web3
- Open Source
- Cybersecurity
- Cloud / DevOps

- Social Impact
- Healthcare
- Education
- Sustainability

These categories are for discovery and support purposes only and do not restrict what teams may build.

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9. Hackathon Themes

All projects must align broadly with the overarching event theme:

AI for Real-World Impact

Within this umbrella, teams can build under the following **primary themes**:

Theme 1: AI for Education

Build tools that improve learning, accessibility, personalized teaching, or skill development.

Example directions:

- AI tutoring systems
- doubt-solving assistants
- adaptive learning platforms
- interview prep tools
- academic research assistants
- skill gap analyzers
- learning analytics dashboards
- study planners

Theme 2: Healthcare & Well-Being

Build solutions that improve healthcare access, health literacy, patient workflows, or wellness outcomes.

Example directions:

- symptom triage systems
- appointment and queue optimization
- medical information explainers
- medication adherence tools
- mental well-being journaling apps
- AI copilots for health documentation
- wellness recommendation engines

> **Note:** Projects in this theme must avoid unsafe medical claims and should clearly state that they are not a substitute for professional care.

Theme 3: Climate, Sustainability & Smart Cities

Build solutions for energy efficiency, environmental monitoring, waste management, mobility, and sustainable decision-making.

Example directions:

- carbon footprint dashboards
- energy optimization assistants
- smart waste segregation systems
- climate risk awareness tools
- water usage monitoring dashboards
- public transit route intelligence
- local environmental reporting systems

Theme 4: Productivity & Work Automation

Build tools that save time, automate workflows, reduce repetitive tasks, and improve decision making.

Example directions:

- meeting summarizers
- email drafting copilots
- workflow automators
- AI project assistants
- task decomposition agents
- knowledge management systems
- browser-based productivity tools

Theme 5: Financial Inclusion & Fintech

Build solutions that improve access to finance, budgeting, literacy, savings, or transaction intelligence.

Example directions:

- expense analyzers
- small business finance dashboards
- loan literacy assistants
- invoice automation systems
- fraud awareness tools
- personal finance coaches
- MSME bookkeeping copilots

Theme 6: Accessibility & Inclusion

Build technology that removes barriers for users with disabilities or underrepresented needs.

Example directions:

- screen-reader-friendly interfaces
- speech-to-text tools
- visual assistance systems
- dyslexia-friendly reading apps
- sign-language support tools
- accessibility testing copilots
- low-bandwidth interfaces

Theme 7: Community, Governance & Civic Tech

Build tools that improve access to public information, local problem reporting, transparency, and community coordination.

Example directions:

- grievance tracking tools
- local issue reporting platforms
- policy explainers
- public resource finders
- community volunteer matching apps
- emergency information systems

Theme 8: Open Innovation

If your project solves a meaningful problem but does not neatly fit into the themes above, you may submit under **Open Innovation**.

Examples:

- developer tools
- creative AI
- browser extensions
- collaboration software
- personal knowledge systems
- startup infrastructure tools

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10. Special Tracks

In addition to main themes, HackForge 2026 includes **special tracks** sponsored or curated for extra recognition.

Track A: Best Use of Generative AI

For projects that meaningfully use LLMs, multimodal models, generative pipelines, or agentic workflows.

Evaluation focus:

- usefulness of AI integration
- quality of prompt / orchestration design
- grounding / retrieval quality
- responsible AI usage
- latency and UX

Track B: Best Beginner Hack

For teams where the majority of members are participating in their **first or second hackathon**.

Evaluation focus:

- learning effort
- execution quality
- problem clarity
- team growth
- presentation

Track C: Best Design & UX

For teams with exceptional product thinking, usability, accessibility, interface design, and storytelling.

Evaluation focus:

- interface quality
- user journey
- clarity of interactions
- onboarding experience
- accessibility

Track D: Best Social Impact Project

For solutions that can positively impact communities, public systems, or underrepresented users.

Track E: Best Developer Tool

For tools that help developers build, debug, document, test, deploy, or learn faster.

Track F: Best Data-Driven Solution

For projects where data analysis, visualization, prediction, or intelligent decision systems are central.

Track G: Best Open Source Potential

For projects that show strong promise for open-source adoption, community contribution, or ecosystem value.

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11. Problem Statements

Participants are free to build open-ended solutions, but below are **sample problem statements** to inspire teams.

Education

- Students struggle to turn long lecture videos into structured notes and actionable learning plans.
- Learners often lack personalized feedback while preparing for interviews or exams.
- Institutions struggle to identify students at risk of disengagement.

Healthcare

- Patients struggle to understand prescriptions, test reports, and follow-up instructions.
- Clinics face workflow inefficiencies in appointment and queue handling.
- Health literacy remains low for many populations.

Climate

- Urban users often lack visibility into daily sustainability metrics.
- Waste segregation is poorly understood at the household level.
- Local communities need better tools to track environmental issues.

Fintech

- Students and first-job earners struggle with budgeting and financial planning.
- Small businesses lack simple financial dashboards and forecasting tools.
- Users often ignore or misunderstand risky financial behavior patterns.

Accessibility

- Many digital products are not designed for neurodivergent users.
- Accessibility testing remains reactive rather than proactive.
- Speech, visual, and motor accessibility tools remain fragmented.

Productivity

- Knowledge workers waste time across scattered tools and tabs.
- Teams need better ways to search and use internal knowledge.
- Repetitive documentation and meeting tasks reduce actual work time.

Participants may use these as-is, extend them, or define their own problem statement.

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12. Datasets & APIs

Participants may use publicly available or self-collected data, provided they have the legal right to do so.

Below are some **sample datasets and APIs** recommended for building.

Education Datasets

- student performance datasets
- open educational resources metadata
- course completion datasets
- question-answer corpora
- educational taxonomy datasets

Suggested use cases:

- adaptive learning
- study recommendation systems
- learning analytics
- academic assistants

Healthcare/Public Health Datasets

- public hospital data
- disease prevalence reports
- health facility accessibility data
- health awareness datasets
- anonymized symptom or triage datasets

Suggested use cases:

- health literacy tools
- public health dashboards
- wellness analytics
- access optimization

No personally identifiable health data should be used without proper consent and legal compliance.

Climate & Sustainability Datasets

- air quality data
- weather data
- rainfall and water data
- waste generation statistics
- energy consumption data
- urban transport data

Suggested use cases:

- sustainability dashboards
- route optimization
- environmental awareness apps
- resource planning systems

Finance Datasets

- anonymized transaction categories
- budgeting datasets
- inflation / CPI data
- expense forecasting data
- financial literacy resources

Suggested use cases:

- spending intelligence
- budget coaching
- financial dashboards
- small business support

Accessibility Resources

- accessibility audit guidelines
- screen reader compatibility docs
- speech corpora
- captioning datasets
- plain-language corpora

Suggested use cases:

- accessibility copilots
- reading assistants
- voice interfaces
- inclusive UX tools

Suggested APIs

Participants may optionally use:

- OpenAI-compatible APIs
- Hugging Face Inference APIs
- Groq / Cerebras / Together-style inference providers
- speech-to-text APIs
- OCR APIs
- translation APIs
- maps / geolocation APIs

- weather APIs
- productivity APIs (calendar / email / docs)
- vector databases / retrieval systems
- analytics APIs

Important API Rule

Teams are fully responsible for ensuring their chosen APIs comply with:

- rate limits,
- usage terms,
- privacy requirements,
- and hackathon policies.

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13. Resources Provided to Participants

HackForge 2026 may provide participants with access to the following resources:

Learning Resources

- kickoff guide
- starter repositories
- API setup tutorials
- Git/GitHub onboarding
- deployment tutorials
- AI app architecture sessions
- prompt engineering basics
- RAG implementation walkthroughs

Productivity Resources

- Notion template
- pitch deck template
- README template
- problem statement worksheet
- judging checklist
- final submission checklist

Technical Resources

- sandbox credits (limited)
- cloud credits (sponsor dependent)
- model/API trial credits (sponsor dependent)
- deployment vouchers (limited)
- dev tools access (where applicable)

Availability may vary depending on sponsor agreements.

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14. Discord Server Structure

The **official HackForge Discord server** will serve as the primary communication hub.

Important Channels

Information Channels

- `#welcome`
- `#rules`
- `#announcements`
- `#schedule`
- `#faq`
- `#resources`

Community Channels

- `#introductions`
- `#team-up`
- `#general-chat`
- `#show-and-tell`
- `#wins-and-progress`

Support Channels

- `#help-desk`
- `#technical-support`
- `#submission-support`
- `#mentor-requests`
- `#sponsor-queries`

Track-Specific Channels

- `#ai-track`
- `#health-track`
- `#climate-track`
- `#fintech-track`
- `#accessibility-track`
- `#devtools-track`

Voice Channels

- mentor office hours
- team collaboration rooms
- workshop stage
- judge waiting room
- organizer support room

All important updates will be announced in `#announcements`. Participants are expected to keep notifications enabled for critical channels.

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15. Event Timeline (Detailed)

Below is the **full event flow**.

Pre-Hackathon Phase

Day -14 to Day -3

- registrations open
- team formation
- onboarding
- community introductions
- optional team matchmaking

Day -2

- orientation session
- platform walkthrough
- sponsor intros
- theme deep dive

Day -1

- workshops
- API demos
- deployment prep
- “how to pitch” session
- Q&A

Hackathon Start — Day 1

6:00 PM IST — Opening Ceremony

- welcome note
- rule briefing
- sponsor announcements
- challenge reveal
- Q&A

7:00 PM IST — Hacking Begins

Teams can start ideation, setup, and development.

8:00 PM IST — Team Check-In Window

All teams should ensure:

- Discord roles are correct
- team details are locked
- GitHub repos are created

- project idea is drafted

10:00 PM IST — Mentor Window 1

Open office hours begin.

Day 2

9:00 AM IST — Progress Checkpoint

Teams are encouraged to:

- define scope
- finalize MVP
- start core implementation

11:00 AM IST — Mentor Window 2

Mentors available across tracks.

2:00 PM IST — Sponsor Challenge AMA

Optional Q&A with sponsors.

5:00 PM IST — Midpoint Review

Recommended internal checklist:

- is the core problem clear?
- is the MVP achievable?
- what must be cut?
- what can still be polished?

8:00 PM IST — Pitch Clinic

Optional session on storytelling and demos.

11:00 PM IST — Mentor Window 3

Late-night support and unblock session.

Day 3 — Submission Day

9:00 AM IST — Final Build Sprint

Teams should focus on:

- bug fixes
- demo stability
- README quality
- deployment

- video recording
- slide deck

1:00 PM IST — Submission Support Window

Final help for upload issues.

4:00 PM IST — Last Call Reminder

All teams should complete:

- project form
- GitHub repo link
- live demo / video link
- presentation deck
- tech stack details

6:00 PM IST — Submission Deadline

No late submissions unless platform failure is officially acknowledged by organizers.

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16. Mentorship Program

Mentorship is one of the strongest parts of HackForge 2026. Teams will have access to mentors from industry, startups, research labs, and open-source communities.

How Mentorship Works

Participants can:

- ask questions in public channels,
- request mentor office hours,
- join mentor voice sessions,
- receive technical or product guidance,
- get feedback on scope and presentation.

Mentor Expectations

Mentors will help teams with:

- problem scoping
- architecture advice
- UX direction
- AI system design
- deployment help
- startup viability
- demo polish

Mentors will **not**:

- build your project for you,
- write your entire codebase,
- guarantee judging outcomes,

- provide private unfair advantages.

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17. Mentor Directory

Below is a **sample mentor list** for your bot testing.

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1. Aditi Sharma

Role: Senior ML Engineer
Organization: NeuralStack Labs
Speciality:

- machine learning pipelines
- model evaluation
- NLP systems
- recommendation systems
- RAG architectures

Can help with:

- choosing the right ML approach
- embeddings and retrieval
- LLM integration
- data preprocessing

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2. Rohan Mehta

Role: Staff Backend Engineer
Organization: ScaleGrid Systems
Speciality:

- backend architecture
- APIs
- authentication
- database design
- scaling MVPs

Can help with:

- Node.js / Python backend
- system design
- deployment issues
- API structure

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3. Priya Nair

Role: Product Designer
Organization: PixelNorth
Speciality:

- UX design
- design systems
- accessibility
- mobile-first interfaces
- onboarding flows

Can help with:

- wireframes
- usability issues
- design critiques
- product polish

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4. Arjun Kapoor

Role: AI Research Associate
Organization: Open Compute Research Lab
Speciality:

- transformers
- prompt engineering
- multimodal systems
- model benchmarking
- AI safety basics

Can help with:

- model selection
- prompt workflows
- eval pipelines
- hallucination reduction

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5. Sneha Iyer

Role: Data Scientist
Organization: InsightForge Analytics
Speciality:

- data cleaning
- dashboards
- feature engineering
- business analytics
- experimentation

Can help with:

- data visualization
- predictive modeling

- metrics selection
- dashboard storytelling

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6. Kabir Sethi

Role: Founder
Organization: BuildSprint AI
Speciality:

- startup strategy
- MVP scoping
- pitch decks
- product-market fit
- founder storytelling

Can help with:

- choosing what not to build
- pitch refinement
- go-to-market framing
- business use cases

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7. Nisha Verma

Role: Accessibility Consultant
Organization: Inclusive Digital Collective
Speciality:

- WCAG basics
- accessible interfaces
- inclusive content design
- assistive tech compatibility

Can help with:

- accessibility audits
- inclusive UX
- screen-reader-friendly flows
- usability for diverse users

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8. Dev Malhotra

Role: DevOps Engineer
Organization: CloudFoundry Edge
Speciality:

- Docker
- CI/CD
- deployment

- cloud hosting
- observability

Can help with:

- deploying apps
- GitHub Actions
- Docker setup
- infrastructure debugging

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9. Fatima Khan

Role: Full Stack Engineer
Organization: AppLayer Studio
Speciality:

- React / Next.js
- frontend architecture
- Firebase / Supabase
- rapid MVP development

Can help with:

- frontend implementation
- auth flows
- dashboards
- app structure

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10. Harshit Rao

Role: Security Engineer
Organization: SecureMesh
Speciality:

- web security
- auth security
- secrets management
- secure APIs
- vulnerability basics

Can help with:

- protecting APIs
- auth flows
- basic threat awareness
- secure deployment practices

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18. Judging Process

The evaluation process is designed to be fair, transparent, and multi-stage.

Stage 1: Submission Screening

All valid submissions will be reviewed for:

- completeness,
- originality,
- alignment with hackathon rules,
- functional viability.

Incomplete or invalid submissions may be disqualified before judging.

Stage 2: Preliminary Judging

Each eligible submission will be scored by a panel of judges based on the official judging criteria.

Judges may review:

- GitHub repository
- README
- pitch deck
- demo video
- live product link
- submitted documentation

Top teams from this round will advance.

Stage 3: Finalist Demo Round

Shortlisted teams will be invited to present live.

This round may include:

- live demo
- Q&A
- architecture discussion
- business or impact discussion
- implementation tradeoff questions

Final rankings will be based on both the initial score and the final presentation, depending on category.

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19. Judging Criteria

Projects will be scored across the following dimensions:

1. Problem Relevance (20 points)

How meaningful and well-defined is the problem being solved?

Judges will look for:

- clarity of user problem
- importance of use case
- evidence of real-world need
- user empathy

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2. Solution Quality (20 points)

How well does the proposed solution address the problem?

Judges will look for:

- solution fit
- practicality
- coherence
- thoughtful feature choices

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3. Technical Execution (20 points)

How well was the project built?

Judges will look for:

- implementation quality
- system design
- integration quality
- robustness
- technical ambition relative to scope

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4. Innovation & Creativity (15 points)

Is the project fresh, insightful, or creatively executed?

Judges will look for:

- originality
- novel combinations
- non-obvious solutions
- strong product insight

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5. Design & User Experience (10 points)

How usable and polished is the product?

Judges will look for:

- interface quality
- clarity of navigation
- accessibility
- product polish

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6. Impact & Scalability (10 points)

Can this solution create meaningful value beyond the hackathon?

Judges will look for:

- real-world applicability
- scalability potential
- adoption feasibility
- ecosystem relevance

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7. Presentation & Demo (5 points)

How clearly and convincingly is the project communicated?

Judges will look for:

- concise storytelling
- smooth demo
- strong explanation
- team clarity

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20. Judges Panel

Below is a **sample judge list** for your bot.

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1. Dr. Meenal Arora

Role: Director of Applied AI
Organization: Veritas Intelligence
Expertise:

- AI systems
- model deployment
- enterprise AI adoption

- responsible AI

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2. Rahul Bansal

Role: VP Engineering
Organization: NovaStack
Expertise:

- distributed systems
- product engineering
- technical architecture
- engineering leadership

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3. Tanya Joseph

Role: Principal Product Designer
Organization: CraftFlow
Expertise:

- UX strategy
- product usability
- design systems
- accessibility

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4. Saurabh Menon

Role: Startup Founder & Angel Investor
Organization: LaunchOrbit Ventures
Expertise:

- startup viability
- GTM thinking
- founder storytelling
- product-market fit

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5. Isha Kulkarni

Role: Lead Data Scientist
Organization: SignalGraph Analytics
Expertise:

- analytics systems
- ML evaluation
- business intelligence
- experimentation

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6. Aditya Sen

Role: Open Source Maintainer
Organization: DevCommons
Expertise:

- developer tools
- OSS architecture
- maintainability
- technical documentation

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21. Submission Guidelines

Every team must submit their project before the official deadline using the designated submission platform.

Required Submission Components

Each team must submit:

1. **Project Title**
2. **Team Name**
3. **Team Member Details**
4. **Theme / Track**
5. **Problem Statement**
6. **Solution Summary**
7. **Tech Stack**
8. **GitHub Repository Link**
9. **Live Demo Link** (if available)
10. **Demo Video Link** (mandatory)
11. **Pitch Deck / Presentation Link**
12. **Setup Instructions**
13. **Any credentials / test access** (if needed)
14. **Known limitations**
15. **Future scope**

Demo Video Requirements

The demo video should ideally be:

- **2 to 4 minutes long**
- clearly narrated
- focused on product functionality
- understandable without live explanation

Recommended structure:

- problem (20–30 sec)
- solution (20–30 sec)
- product demo (1.5–2 min)
- tech stack / AI usage (30 sec)

- closing impact statement (15 sec)

README Requirements

Your GitHub README should include:

- project title
- problem statement
- features
- architecture overview
- tech stack
- setup steps
- screenshots
- usage guide
- team member roles

Projects with poor documentation may lose points in usability and presentation.

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22. Demo Day Rules

Finalist teams will present live before the judges.

Presentation Format

Each finalist team will receive:

- **5 minutes** for presentation and demo
- **3 minutes** for judge Q&A

Recommended Pitch Flow

1. Problem
2. Why it matters
3. Your solution
4. Product walkthrough
5. Tech stack / architecture
6. Why your solution stands out
7. Future roadmap

Live Demo Expectations

Teams should:

- keep backup screenshots/video ready,
- avoid relying on unstable internet,
- test all demo links in advance,
- have one clear speaker and one technical backup.

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23. Prize Pool & Awards

The total dummy prize pool for HackForge 2026 is:

₹4,50,000 + Sponsor Credits + Internship Opportunities

Main Awards

Grand Winner

₹1,20,000

- Winner certificate
- featured showcase
- sponsor credits
- mentorship fast-track

1st Runner-Up

₹75,000

2nd Runner-Up

₹50,000

Track Awards

Best Use of Generative AI

₹25,000

Best Beginner Hack

₹20,000

Best Design & UX

₹20,000

Best Social Impact Project

₹20,000

Best Developer Tool

₹20,000

Best Data-Driven Solution

₹20,000

Best Open Source Potential

₹20,000

Special Recognition Awards

Most Ambitious Hack

₹10,000

Most Practical Solution

₹10,000

Community Favorite

₹10,000

Best Pitch

₹10,000

Best Solo Project

₹10,000

Non-Cash Benefits

Selected teams may also receive:

- cloud credits
- AI API credits
- startup mentorship
- incubation shortlisting
- hiring referrals
- open-source spotlight
- sponsor internship opportunities

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24. Sponsor Benefits & Sponsored Challenges

HackForge 2026 includes a range of sponsors and ecosystem partners.

Title Sponsor

NovaMind AI

Category: Generative AI Infrastructure

Sponsored Challenge

Build an AI-powered assistant, workflow, or agent using LLM-powered reasoning and retrieval.

Prize

₹30,000 + API credits

Cloud Sponsor

SkyCompute

Category: Cloud / Deployment / Infra

Sponsored Challenge

Deploy a production-ready app with scalable backend and proper documentation.

Prize

₹20,000 + cloud credits

Data Sponsor

DataNest

Category: Analytics & BI

Sponsored Challenge

Create a strong data-driven dashboard or intelligence tool.

Prize

₹15,000 + analytics tooling credits

Design Partner

PixelMint

Category: Design & Prototyping

Sponsored Challenge

Build the most usable and visually polished product.

Prize

₹15,000

Developer Ecosystem Partner

CodeDock

Category: Developer Tools

Sponsored Challenge

Build a tool that improves developer workflows.

Prize

₹15,000

Community Partner Sponsors

- DevLaunch Community
- Women Build Tech
- Open Source Circle
- Campus Innovators Network
- AI Builders India

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25. Code of Conduct

HackForge 2026 is committed to creating a respectful, inclusive, and safe environment for everyone.

All participants, mentors, judges, sponsors, organizers, and volunteers are expected to behave professionally and respectfully.

Unacceptable Behavior Includes

- harassment
- hate speech
- intimidation
- discrimination
- bullying
- personal attacks

- stalking
- inappropriate DMs
- explicit or abusive language
- spam or disruption
- cheating or sabotage

Respect Includes

- constructive communication
- patience with beginners
- professionalism during demos
- respecting mentor and organizer time
- giving credit fairly

Violation of the code of conduct may result in:

- warning,
- mute,
- Discord removal,
- disqualification,
- event ban.

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26. Fair Play & Anti-Cheating Policy

Hackathons are competitive, but they must also be fair.

Participants Must Not

- submit copied projects,
- reuse a fully completed old project without declaring it,
- steal another team's code or idea implementation,
- falsify build progress,
- manipulate judging,
- impersonate mentors/judges,
- spam channels for unfair promotion.

Use of Existing Code

Using libraries, frameworks, templates, and boilerplate is allowed.

Using pre-built internal components is also allowed **only if clearly disclosed**.

Disclosure Rule

If your project uses:

- prebuilt backend auth boilerplate,
- a previous starter repo,
- an old dashboard shell,
- a template app,

- or any code written before the hackathon,

you must mention it in your submission.

Important Principle

Judges reward **what was built during the event**, not just what was assembled.

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27. Intellectual Property Policy

Participants retain ownership of the intellectual property they create during the hackathon.

However, by participating, teams grant organizers a non-exclusive right to:

- feature project names,
- showcase screenshots,
- publish demo clips,
- include summaries in event recaps,
- promote winners and finalists.

If your project includes third-party IP, licensed assets, or proprietary APIs, you are responsible for ensuring compliance.

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28. Use of AI Tools Policy

Since HackForge 2026 is centered around modern building workflows, **AI-assisted development is allowed**.

Participants may use tools such as:

- code assistants
- AI pair programmers
- LLMs
- image generation tools
- writing assistants
- prompt tools
- model APIs

However

You are still expected to:

- understand your implementation,
- disclose major AI-assisted components if asked,
- ensure your solution is not unsafe or misleading,
- avoid violating copyright or privacy.

Judging Note

Using AI does **not automatically increase your score**.

Projects will be judged on:

- value,
- execution,
- originality,
- clarity,
- and responsible usage.

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29. Technical Requirements

There is no fixed tech stack requirement, but projects should ideally be:

- demonstrable,
- reasonably functional,
- understandable,
- and documented.

Recommended Minimum Standards

Your project should ideally include:

- a frontend or usable interface,
- backend / logic layer (if applicable),
- data flow clarity,
- README documentation,
- demo video,
- deployment or local run instructions.

Strongly Recommended

- use GitHub for version control,
- keep commits meaningful,
- include screenshots,
- prepare fallback demo assets,
- test your flows before submission.

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30. Support & Help Channels

Participants may seek help through the following methods:

For Technical Issues

Use:

- `#technical-support`
- `#mentor-requests`

For Event / Rule Questions

Use:

- `#help-desk`
- `#faq`

For Submission Problems

Use:

- `#submission-support`

For Team Matchmaking

Use:

- `#team-up`

Escalation

If an urgent issue is unresolved, tag:

- `@Organizer`
- `@Mod`
- `@Tech Support`

Do not spam DMs to mentors or judges unless they have explicitly invited private communication.

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31. Media, Recording & Publicity

By participating in HackForge 2026, you acknowledge that portions of the event may be recorded or photographed for event recap, marketing, and community purposes.

This may include:

- workshop screenshots,
- Discord stage recordings,
- finalist presentations,
- winner interviews,
- project showcase posts.

If your team has special confidentiality concerns, contact organizers in advance.

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32. Accommodation & Onsite Finale (If Shortlisted)

If your team is shortlisted for the onsite finale, further instructions will be shared separately.

These may include:

- venue details

- reporting time
- travel reimbursement policy (if any)
- accommodation support (if any)
- ID verification requirements
- presentation schedule
- final demo booth guidelines

Shortlisted teams may be required to confirm attendance within a limited window.

Failure to respond may result in slot reassignment.

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33. Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. Can I participate solo?

Yes. Solo participation is allowed.

Q2. Can beginners participate?

Absolutely. HackForge 2026 is beginner-friendly.

Q3. Can I use AI tools like ChatGPT or Copilot?

Yes, unless your use violates any policy or becomes deceptive.

Q4. Can I start building before the hackathon begins?

You may ideate and research beforehand, but the actual build should primarily happen during the hackathon window.

Q5. Can I use an old project?

You may build on an old idea or base infrastructure only if clearly disclosed. Fully recycled projects are not allowed.

Q6. Is deployment mandatory?

Not strictly, but highly recommended. At minimum, your project should be runnable and clearly demonstrated.

Q7. Is the demo video mandatory?

Yes. It is mandatory for all valid submissions.

Q8. What if my app breaks during the live demo?

Keep backup screenshots and a backup walkthrough video.

Q9. Can one person be in multiple teams?

No.

Q10. Can I change my team after registration?

Yes, until the team editing deadline.

Q11. What if I miss the deadline due to internet issues?

Only platform-wide or organizer-acknowledged incidents may qualify for exceptions.

Q12. Can non-coders participate?

Yes. Designers, researchers, storytellers, analysts, and product thinkers are welcome.

Q13. Will there be certificates?

Yes. Participation certificates will be issued to eligible participants who comply with event requirements.

Q14. Can international teams join?

Yes, subject to legal and logistical feasibility.

Q15. Are hardware hacks allowed?

Software-first prototypes with hardware integrations are welcome if demoable.

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34. Closing Note

HackForge 2026 is designed to reward teams that build with intention.

You do not need the flashiest stack.
You do not need the most complicated AI pipeline.
You do not need a perfect startup by Sunday evening.

What you *do* need is:

- a meaningful problem,
- a focused MVP,
- a working prototype,
- clear communication,
- and a thoughtful user-centered solution.

The best hackathon teams are rarely the ones that try to build everything. They are the teams that **choose wisely, execute clearly, and present convincingly**.

We encourage you to:

- start simple,
- cut scope aggressively,

- validate your assumptions,
- document your work,
- and ship something real.

We’re excited to see what you build.

Build boldly. Build responsibly. Build what matters.

— Team HackForge 2026